

You will pay for that

I was tempted to use the headline “Piracy is dead” for this column, but it’s become such a common usage by journalists these days, that it seemed a little clichéd.

Back when it started, this magazine grew popular, in part, because it exposed you to tonnes of new software that were too painful to download. It was also a lot harder to find “cracks” for software online back then. However, some industrious fans put up a site called Crack Digit, which was dedicated to finding and providing keygens and serials for all the popular trials and shareware we provided in our CDs. Of course, worried about being blamed for spreading piracy in India, we started promoting open source software, and succeeded in bringing a few of you back from the dark-side.

I remember huge companies – Microsoft, Adobe, etc. – screaming bloody murder, and denouncing piracy to be as evil as Satan, and claiming that piracy was costing them more than they were already worth. Then there was the MPAA and RIAA, and over the last decade we’ve all heard the stories of little kids and grandmas being dragged to court and humiliated. Tall claims were made, and the rich cried “Foul!” as Napster, Audio Galaxy, and much later, KaZaA and Bit Torrent were blamed for putting recording industry executives in the poor house. Apparently the poor in the west live in multi-million dollar mansions, drive Lamborghinis and own private jets; but that’s a rant for another time.

It was only last year that the US government did a study and admitted that the MPAA and RIAA had bloated piracy reports way beyond proportion, and actual piracy or “losses” as they put it, were significantly lower. So basically they lied; of course it was all blamed on “human error”.

Living in India, we’re so used to piracy, it’s really no big deal. Actually, if you’ve noticed, it’s even less of a deal these days. At one time the news was flooded with reports of raids and arrests of pirates. These days, when people talk about pirates, they mean the AK-47 toting Somali kind. We’ve come full circle, haven’t we?

The fact is that piracy (in the technology sense, not the Somali sense) is dying a slow death – even here in India.

Before you dash off incredulous but anonymous letters to me, stating that I’m going senile, and sending me screen-

shots as proud evidence of your desire to wear an eye patch, humour me a little.

Open up that RSS feed reader or visit your favourite technology news site, and scan through the news. All you’re likely to see is Apple this, Google that, Android the other, apps, apps and more apps. Of course there will be generous sprinklings of 3D, LED TVs, Blu-ray, gaming consoles, and a whisper of Intel, Microsoft and the rest.

A few years ago, Microsoft started cashing in on the shift from desktops to laptops. Bundling the OS with the device made them billions, and gave us all a (gasp!) *licensed* version of Windows that needed no special tricks to connect to Windows Update! Thus started the conversion; however, laptops are still bulky and that’s why we’re all slowly shifting to mobiles now. That’s Apple’s and Google’s domain though.

The proof is in the GPU growth figures from companies such as NVIDIA and ATI – GPUs in 2009 saw about a 10 per cent growth, and even conservative estimates pegged the 2010 story to be close to 25 per cent growth in sales. In reality, reports suggest that the GPU market grew by a mere 3 or 4 per cent.

What’s happened now is that technology is inching ahead of us again. Just as it was almost impossible to download a movie over a dial-up connection a decade ago, it’s insane to try and download a 3D Blu-ray rip over our current connections. So we go to the theatre, and pay to watch movies in 3D.

We’ve stopped complaining about music prices too, because they’re just cheap little downloads for your phone. “Software” as we know it is niche already – unless you mean “Mobile apps”, because those are crazy popular now, and don’t cost an arm or a leg anyway.

Gradually, we’re being shifted away from large screen computing to small screen devices; from big bloated software that cost a fortune to small, single feature apps that cost a pittance; from OSes that try to do everything to those that do very little, but do it well, and open up possibilities to developers to add functionality to your phone. The end of piracy approaches, as does the end of popular computing as we know it! 



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